

Diploma in Leadership & Management

**Invest in your
career path**



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of what a career path is. The students will also receive examples of different paths and how to select the correct path for themselves. This lesson is aimed at creating a long-term path and also looking at the importance of professional networking.

Introduction

This lesson is all about you as a manager and leader. Now that you have more information about strategic thinking and planning as well as insight when it comes to time management, we need to move on to career planning. This is a lesson for each of you to think about your short and long-term goals in relation to your career path. Keep in mind to look at each lesson to improve yourself but also look at how you can use this lesson as a coaching tool. Someone in your team might need help with their career path and these terms and approaches will give you the insight to help them best you can.

Key reading materials:

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jpe-LKn-4gM>
- <https://www.callutheran.edu/students/career-services/career-counseling/six-steps-career-planning.html>
- <https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/resumes-cover-letters/networking-skills-on-resume>

How to create a career path plan:

According to (Heathfield, n.d.) Career pathing is the process used by an employee to chart a course within an organization for his or her career path and career development. Career pathing involves understanding what knowledge, skills, personal characteristics, and experience are required for an employee to progress his or her career laterally, or through access to promotions and/or departmental transfers. Career pathing requires an employee to take an honest look at his or her career goals, skills, needed knowledge, experience, and personal characteristics. Career pathing requires the employee to make a plan to obtain what is necessary for each of these areas to carry out his or her career path.

Things to consider when developing a career path:

Decide on your career goals and desired jobs:

You can speak to mentors, colleagues and other professionals about career options and advice. You can also spend time on your own to research different options. You can also take careers test and quizzes that will help you gain insight.

Put it in writing:

If you are lucky enough to work within an organization that has an employee performance and/or career development process, the written plan is an integral component. If not, put your own plan in writing and share it with your supervisor, human resources, and involved others. Writing down your goals is an integral part of achieving them.

Its up to you

You are the person who has to make the decision. You have to put in the time and effort to speak to different people, to do the research and to select a path that you want to take.

How to Support Effective Career Path Planning and Development

Employees want to see and understand their next opportunities within their company. This is especially important for ambitious employees who want and expect to see career development opportunities to be satisfied and motivated at work.

A thoughtful career path plan is a key factor in employee engagement and employee retention. An organization contributes to an employee's ability to develop a career path by making the knowledge, skills, experience, and job requirements for each position within the company transparent. With this information, the employee can plan and prepare for various jobs and opportunities.

The organization supports employees in developing and pursuing a career path by providing access to these opportunities and information.

- Job descriptions
- Job specifications
- Required competencies
- A responsive internal job application process
- Access to employees doing the job currently
- Training classes
- On-the-job developmental opportunities
- Job shadowing
- Mentoring
- Promotions
- Transfers or lateral moves
- Coaching from the supervisor
- A formal succession planning process

With access to these processes and systems, every employee should have the opportunity to pursue a career path.

Types of career paths:

According to (Indeed, n.d.)

Multiple unrelated jobs:

Your career could be made up of multiple jobs that are unrelated to one another. For example, you could work as a sales associate in a retail environment, then as a server in a restaurant and then as a receptionist in a veterinary clinic. Because each job is vastly different than the next, there is no way to predict what your next position will be. Because they have very little in common, you may not see significant pay increases from one to the next or significant increases in responsibility.

Advancing within one occupation:

This path involves advancing in the same occupation, whether you work for the same organization or at different establishments. For example, if you are working as a cashier, you could eventually be moved to a customer service position where you operate a cash register but also handle customer service issues. Eventually, you could be moved to a head cashier position, supervising the other cashiers.

Advancing in the same industry but not occupation:

This path involves staying in the same industry, but not necessarily the same occupation. For example, if your goal is to be a manager at a restaurant, you could start out as a dishwasher, then move to a server position, then head server or assistant manager and eventually manager.

Career mapping

Please note that this template and examples is provided by Indeed:

Career maps help both employers and employees. They offer plans for success and identify areas of opportunity within an organization. With a company-wide career map determined, organizations can set goals and make major decisions for the betterment of the company.

What is career mapping?

Career mapping is the process by which employers create methods for individual advancement within their company. Career maps explain the requirements for advancement at each stage of an employee's career. Employees often create

their own career maps as they identify their own course of progression within an organisation. They create their own progression routes and determine the requirements needed to get from their entry-level position to their goal.

Career mapping template

With the basic steps for creating a career path in mind, using a template becomes simple. The following sections outline the basics of an effective career map:

[Starting job title: Your first section outlines all the details surrounding the starting point. Include a full job description.]

[Bullet point defining further requirements]

[Bullet point defining personality profile details]

[A heading introducing goals. Ensure your goals are both relevant and achievable. Consider the S.M.A.R.T system when determining objectives as it creates more effective goals. Goals between career stages often include years of work experience, the number of positive work reviews, specific achievements or rewards earned or other related feats. Include as many as needed for the specific role.]

[Goal 1]

[Goal 2]

[Goal 3]

[Ending job title: This final section outlines all the details surrounding the ending point. Treat it similarly to the starting point and include a job description and a personality profile.]

Career mapping example

Now that you understand how to create a career map, use the provided template to create your own. Below is an example of a two-stage career map using the template:

***Administrative Assistant**:** Handles minor office tasks such as filing, report taking, data entry and multi-line phone management. With proficient expertise in applications such as Excel and PowerPoint, creates organized spreadsheets and meeting presentations. Greet and assist all visitors as necessary.

- Requirements include an associate degree in administrative assisting or related field and at least one year of previous experience
- Outgoing personality with a passion for customer service

There are three goals for this position:

1. At least 3 continuous years of employment
2. Discover and implement at least one method of improving customer service
3. Attend one training seminar on the principles of management

***Assistant Office Manager**:** Monitors daily activities involving the office and concierge desk. Schedules building maintenance operations as needed throughout the year. Maintains employee records and managerial procedures. Assists Office Manager as needed.

Career paths examples

Retail: Sales Associate > Assistant Management > Store Manager > Regional Manager

Human Resources: HR Assistant > HR Specialist > Assistant Director Of HR > Director Of HR

Editorial: Editorial Assistant > Assistant Editor > Editor > Senior Editor > Editorial Director

Networking skills

According to (Inc. , n.d.)

Set goals:

Set small achievable goals for yourself. For example, you would like to great a LinkedIn page and gain 200 followers. You will then share articles, like and comment on content and you would like to achieve this within 2 months. You can use your SMART goal system to create this goal with measurables and a clear timeline.

Quality over quantity:

Make sure that you're attending events that you care about and that you would like to explore. This way you will meet the correct and likeminded people. When you're connecting on social media, you can do the same. Look for people with similar roles, and interests.

Do your research:

It's important to know who's going to be at an event, which you can often do by checking social media--conference hashtags on Twitter are a good place to start. Then make a shortlist of people you want to meet. Do some Googling and view LinkedIn profiles so when you do meet someone new you'll know something about them.

Network on the fly:

This is a good tip for people who are not comfortable with networking. You don't have to go to an event or wait for the correct moment. You can network with different people around you. For example, making small talk at a birthday party while waiting in line for coffee. It's about being comfortable when speaking to new people. Try it out and see if you feel more comfortable over time.

Focus on social media:

Engage with people online from all different backgrounds. You can look for different perspectives, influencers on different social media platforms. This is also a great way to look for up-to-date information and you can spot trends using this method.

References

- Heathfield, S. (n.d.). How to Make a Career Path Plan. Retrieved from The Balance careers: <https://www.thebalancecareers.com/career-pathing-1918080>
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- Indeed. (n.d.). Career Paths. Retrieved from Indeed: <https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/career-development/what-is-a-career> Onstrategy . (n.d.). Essentials Guide to Strategic Planning. Retrieved from Onstrategy : <https://onstrategyhq.com/resources/strategic-planning-process-basics/>